

64. English
Common errors
(PART IV)

rise

- x Buy now -- they will ~~rise~~ the price next week. [149]
 - ✓ Buy now -- they will **raise** the price next week.
 - ✓ Buy now -- the price will **rise** next week.
- Prices/fares/charges/ taxes etc 'rise' but they are 'raised' by people. 'Rise' is also a noun:
- ✓ There will be a **rise** in prices next week.

safety

- x We found a ~~safety~~ place to hide. [150]
 - ✓ We found a **safe** place to hide.
- 'Safety' is a noun; the adjective is 'safe'.

sales

- x I asked a ~~sales~~ if I could have a discount. [42]
 - ✓ I asked a **salesperson** if I could have a discount.
- 'Sales' cannot refer to a person; someone who sells things is a 'salesperson/saleswoman/salesman' or, in a shop, a 'sales assistant'.

scene

- x A typhoon is a common ~~scene~~ in Hong Kong. [43]
 - ✓ A typhoon is a common **occurrence** in Hong Kong.
- A 'scene' is not an event/occurrence. It can be the place where an event happens; or it can be what one sees:
- ✓ The police hurried to the **scene** of the crime.

scenery

- x There are some beautiful ~~sceneries~~ in the New Territories. [175]
 - ✓ There is some beautiful **scenery** in the New Territories.
- 'Scenery' is uncountable, so cannot be plural or take 'a'.

Although the shops sell many shoes and toys, the words 'shoe' and 'toy' are adjectives describing the shops, so cannot take 's'. Many shop names in Hong Kong are, in this sense, incorrect!

shopping

- x After lunch, we went ~~to shopping~~. [269]
 - ✓ After lunch, we went **shopping**.
- 'To' is not used between 'go' and the '-ing' form of a verb. This structure is used for many activities, e.g. to go swimming, to go camping etc.

show

- x Statistics ~~show out~~ how densely populated Hong Kong is. [260]
 - ✓ Statistics **show** how densely populated Hong Kong is.
- Although the Cantonese can use 出 after 顯示, the English never uses 'out' in that way.

since

- x Since it was raining, ~~so~~ we didn't go on the picnic. [334]
 - ✓ Since it was raining, we didn't go on the picnic.
 - ✓ It was raining, **so** we didn't go on the picnic.
- In Cantonese, 因為 and 所以 are used together but in English it must be one or the other, not both.

Sir

- x She went to the teachers' room and asked for Wong ~~Sir~~. [364]
 - ✓ She went to the teachers' room and asked for Mr Wong.
- In Cantonese many professions or positions are given after the surname as a title, e.g. 王老師. However, very few are used as titles in English, two of the only ones being Doctor (medicine or Ph.D.) and Professor. These go before the name. 'Sir' is used when talking to a male teacher, but without the name:
- ✓ May I go now, **Sir**?
 - ✓ Is Mr Wong there, **Sir**?

schoolmate

- x The Principal said, 'We hope all ~~schoolmates~~ will enjoy the party'. [61]
 - ✓ The Principal said, 'We hope all **students** will enjoy the party'.
- Although 同學 is used by Cantonese teachers in speaking to students in their school, 'schoolmates' can only be used in English by students talking to their fellow students of the same school. Others can only use 'schoolmate' in relation to another student in the same school, e.g.:
- ✓ Mrs Jones asked whether any of Anna's **schoolmates** wanted to come on the picnic.

sell

- x They sold ~~out~~ a lot of furniture. [258]
 - ✓ They **sold** a lot of furniture. [259]
- Although Cantonese can use 賣出 for 'sell', the English equivalent cannot use 'out'. 'Sell out' has a different meaning -- to sell the entire stock of something and have no more left to sell:
- ✓ We couldn't buy any armchairs as the shop was **sold out** of them.

service

- x In my job I want to ~~service~~ society. [151]
 - ✓ In my job I want to **serve** society.
- 'Service' is not often used as a verb, in which case it means to 'do maintenance or repairs' e.g. on a car. 'Service' is usually a noun and the verb meaning 'help' or 'give service to' is 'serve'.

shiny

- x It was a beautiful ~~shiny~~ day. [44]
 - ✓ It was a beautiful **sunny** day.
- When the sun shines it is 'sunny'. 'Shiny' is used for things that reflect light, not for sources of light.
- ✓ She found a **shiny** new coin.

shop

- x We went to a ~~shoes~~ shop and then to a ~~toys~~ shop. [205]
- ✓ We went to a **shoe** shop and then to a **toy** shop.

sit

- x I had to cross the harbour, so I ~~sit on~~ a ferry. [369]



- ✓ I had to cross the harbour, so I **took** a ferry.
- Although the Cantonese expression is 搭 for 'taking' buses, trams, trains, ferries, taxis etc, the English is 'take' or 'go by', not 'sit'.

situate

- x That company ~~situates~~ in Hung Hom. [281]
 - ✓ That company **is situated** in Hung Hom.
- The verb 'situate' is used in the passive here.

sleep

- x The children ~~sleep~~ at 9 p.m. most evenings. [77]
 - ✓ The children **go to sleep** at 9 p.m. most evenings.
- Cantonese uses 睡覺 for both 'going to sleep' (i.e. beginning one's sleep) and 'sleeping'. English uses 'sleep' for the whole process:
- ✓ The children **sleep** for nine or ten hours most nights.
- N.B. 'Sleeping late' is not going to sleep late, but sleeping in late the next morning.

so

- x Traffic congestion is ~~so~~ serious in Hong Kong. [329]
- ✓ Traffic congestion is very serious in Hong Kong.
- 'So' with an adjective means 'to such an extent' and should be followed by 'that': [336]
- ✓ Traffic congestion is ~~so~~ serious that it takes me two hours to get to work. It is only used to mean 'very' colloquially;
- ✓ It's ~~so~~ hot today! (an exclamation)
- ✓ I'd be ~~so~~ pleased if you could come.

so-called

- x The ~~so-called~~ Basic Law is a mini-constitution for Hong Kong. [54]
- ✓ The Basic Law is a mini-constitution for Hong Kong.
- 'So-called' should not be used simply to introduce the name of something. It is only used where the writer/speaker doubts the suitability of the name:
- ✓ The ~~so-called~~ 'Deluxe Model' is no better than an ordinary one – it's just more expensive!

so that

- x The window was open ~~so that~~ the people got cold. [335]

I won't close it. I want you to suffer!



70

- often.
- ✓ The cost of living is rising so much we can't afford to go to restaurants so often.
- 'Standard of living' is the material quality of life that people have, so a rise in the standard of living means salaries are rising more than costs and people have more money to spend on luxuries.
- ✓ The standard of living is much higher in the West than in the Third World.

station

- x He was waiting at the bus ~~station~~. [85]
- ✓ He was waiting at the bus stop.
- Trains have 'stations' but buses and trams have 'stops' whereas the Cantonese for both is 站. At each end of a bus or tram line is a 'terminus'.

story book

- x My boss read a ~~story book~~ on the plane to London. [46]



- ✓ My boss read a novel on the plane to London.
- 'Story book' is used for children's stories only. A book-length story for adults is a 'novel'.

stress

- x In her lecture, she ~~stressed on~~ this point. [261]
- ✓ In her lecture, she stressed this point.
- The verb 'stress' takes a direct object.

something

- ✓ The window was open, ~~so~~ the people got cold.
- Only 'so' should be used here to show the result of the window being open.
- 'So that' is used to show the purpose of the action mentioned first:
- ✓ She quickly closed the window ~~so that~~ the people wouldn't get cold.

spend

- x I bought ~~some things~~ in the shop. [107]
- ✓ I bought some things in the shop.
- 'Something' as one word means 'an indefinite thing' and cannot be plural. When several things are meant, two words should be used: 'some things'.

stability

- x The MTR doesn't ~~spend~~ much time from Central to Causeway Bay. [348]
- ✓ The MTR doesn't take much time from Central to Causeway Bay.
- A person 'spends' time doing something, but a journey or a vehicle 'takes' time.

- x Hong Kong ~~is~~ political stability. [152]
- ✓ Hong Kong has political stability.
- ✓ Hong Kong is politically stable.
- 'Stability' is a noun; the adjective is 'stable' and an adjective is modified by an adverb, 'politically'. See also PROSPERITY.

staff

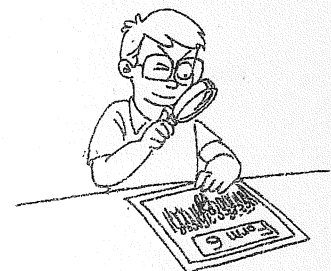
- x I asked a ~~staff~~ where Mr Leung's office was. [206]
- ✓ I asked a member of the staff where Mr Leung's office was.
- 'Staff' is a collective noun for all the employees under the manager of an office/shop or all the teachers under a principal. So 'staff' cannot be used for individuals, just for the group.
- x All our ~~staffs~~ are requested to look out for shoplifters.
- ✓ All our staff are requested to look out for shoplifters.

standard of living

- x The ~~standard~~ of living is rising so much we can't afford to go to restaurants so [45]

study

- 1 x I want to further my ~~study~~ overseas. [207]
- ✓ I want to further my studies overseas.
- Any course involves a number of subjects, so the 'studies' are plural.
- 2 x I am studying ~~Form 6~~ this year. [262]



- ✓ I am studying in Form 6 this year.
- One studies subjects, not a form. Cantonese expressions like 讀中六 and 讀大學 may lead to this error in English, where a preposition is needed, e.g.:
- ✓ She is studying at university.

success

- x He was ~~successed~~ in the exam. [153]
- ✓ He was successful in the exam.
- ✓ He succeeded in the exam.
- 'Success' is not a verb. The verb is 'succeed' and the adjective 'successful'. 'Success' is, in fact, a noun:
- ✓ The fair was certainly a success.

such as

- x There are many places to visit in Hong Kong. ~~Such as~~ the Peak, Ocean Park and the New Territories. [342]
- ✓ There are many places to visit in Hong Kong, such as the Peak, Ocean Park

and the New Territories.
'Such as' can never begin a sentence as it only introduces a list of items.

suggest

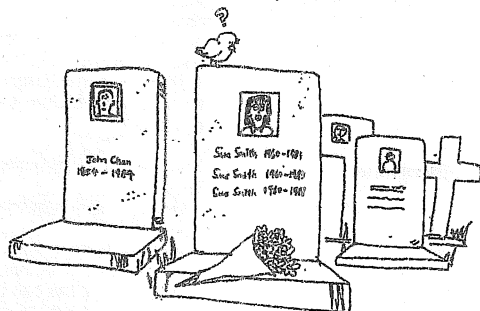


- 1 x I suggested him to buy a new one. [270]
 ✓ I suggested (that) he buy a new one.
 One suggests (that) someone do something, but 'that' is often omitted.
 2 x I suggest that we can see a movie. [123]
 ✓ I suggest that we see a movie.
 'Can' is not used here as the emphasis is on seeing a movie rather than just on the possibility.

suicide



- 1 x He ~~suicided~~ after he lost his job. [288]
 ✓ He committed suicide after he lost his job.
 The Cantonese 自殺 can be both noun and verb but in English 'suicide' is only a noun and takes 'commit' to form a verb.
 2 x She ~~committed~~ suicide three times. [78]



- ✓ She attempted suicide three times.
 To 'commit suicide' is to kill oneself while to 'attempt suicide' is to try and kill oneself but not necessarily succeed.

sunbathe

- x We'll take a sun-bath on the beach. [99]
 ✓ We'll sunbathe on the beach.
 ✓ We'll go sunbathing on the beach.

television.

One sees programmes 'on' TV, hears them 'on' the radio but reads news 'in' the newspaper.

the

- 1 x After a wonderful day at the Ocean Park, we took a bus back to the Central District. [191]
 ✓ After a wonderful day at Ocean Park, we took a bus back to Central District.
 'Ocean Park' does not take 'the' - nor do other parks, gardens, squares: Victoria Park, Chater Garden, Statue Square. One exception is 'the Botanical Gardens'.
 Cities and their districts do not usually take 'the': Central District, Mongkok, Tuen Mun. One exception is 'the New Territories' (because it is plural).
 Likewise: Victoria Harbour, Kai Tak Airport, Kowloon Station, Victoria Peak but 'the Peak'. However, many public buildings do take 'the', including hotels, restaurants, cinemas, theatres and others like the Space Museum, the Hong Kong Coliseum, the Hong Kong Stadium, the City Hall, while residential buildings usually don't, e.g. Hing Wah Mansion, Estoril Court.
 2 x My brother is the doctor at Queen Mary Hospital. [191]



The verb here is to 'sunbathe' with an 'e'. The activity is 'sunbathing'.

sure



- x You cannot ~~sure~~ you'll pass the driving test. [287]
 ✓ You cannot be sure you'll pass the driving test.
 'Sure' is not a verb. Here it is an adjective that follows the verb 'to be'.

surprise



- x I felt so ~~surprise~~ when I heard the news! [154]
 ✓ I felt so surprised when I heard the news!
 'Surprise' is a verb or noun; the adjective for 'feeling surprise' is 'surprised'.

surprising



- x I felt ~~surprising~~ that Jan didn't enter the race. [215]
 ✓ It was surprising that Jan didn't enter the race.
 ✓ I was surprised that Jan didn't enter the race.
 'Surprising' means 'causing surprise'. The writer/speaker didn't cause surprise; what did was the fact that Jan didn't enter the race.

table

- x The teacher told the students to put their books on their tables. [86]
 ✓ The teacher told the students to put their books on their desks.
 In Cantonese 枱 can be used for table and desk, but in English, classrooms have 'desks' for students.

teenage

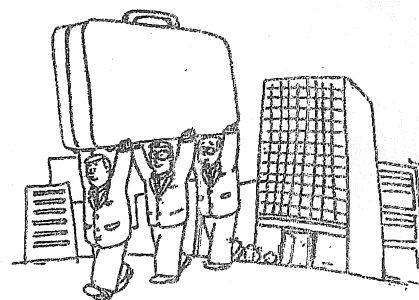
- x She has little experience -- she's still a teenage. [155]
 ✓ She has little experience -- she's still a teenager.
 'Teenage' is an adjective meaning 'between the ages 13 and 19'. A person of this age is a 'teenager'.

television

- x I like to watch the news ~~in~~ the television. [228]
 ✓ I like to watch the news on the television.

their

- ✓ My brother is a doctor at Queen Mary Hospital.
 'The doctor' in the first sentence means he's the only one. 'A doctor' in the second means he's one of a number.
 x Some businessmen came out of the building carrying their briefcases. [208]



- ✓ Some businessmen came out of the building carrying their briefcases.
 There were several men, so there would have been several briefcases (plural), not one.

there



- x ~~There~~ is very crowded. [292]
 ✓ It is very crowded there.
 In the Cantonese 喺度好多人, the term 喺度 is used like a noun, a place which is crowded. In English 'there' is an adverb showing where something happens; it cannot be used like the name of a place. So the form 'It is + adjective' is used, followed by the adverb 'there'.
 'There' does come before the verb 'is' in expressions where 'there' isn't referring to a place, e.g.:
 ✓ There is a man at the door.
 It may be helpful to remember:
 • It is + Adjective or Noun.
 • There is + Noun only.

'There is' can never be followed by an adjective alone.
✓ It is beautiful.
✓ It is Wednesday.
✓ There is a view from the Peak.
x There is beautiful.

those

x On the subject of corruption, I think those business people shouldn't take bribes. [124]
✓ On the subject of corruption, I think business people shouldn't take bribes. 'Those' is often used in Hong Kong when no word is needed in front of the noun. It should only be used to refer to something/someone
a) already referred to before;
b) pointed at, during conversation; or
c) defined by a who/which clause in the same sentence.
Examples:
✓ a) Two men robbed a bank today. Those men deserve a heavy jail sentence.
✓ b) Do you like those shoes? (pointing to them)
✓ c) Those business people who take bribes risk being charged with corruption.

time

x We have been members here for ten years' time. [327]
✓ We have been members here for ten years.
'Time' is unnecessary and wrong here, since 'for' means 'over a period of'. It may be confused with the expression 'in ten years' time' which means 'ten years from now', i.e. at a time in the future.
✓ When we graduated from university we agreed to meet again in ten years' time.

too

x Doug can't go; Liz can't go too. [312]
✓ Doug can't go; Liz can't go either.
When the verb is negative 'either' is used in place of 'too'.

2 x I also went there too. [114]
✓ I also went there.
✓ I went there too.
In this case, 'also' and 'too' mean the same thing, so one or the other should be used, not both.

tool

x The bus is a very popular traffic tool. [55]
✓ The bus is a very popular means of transport.
The Cantonese 交通工具 but 'tool' in English only means implements used in manual work like carpentry, gardening, mechanical and electrical repairs, e.g. hammer, spade, screw-driver. And 交通 can mean 'transport', 'traffic' or 'communications' in English.

traffic

x Traffic in this area is very convenient. [62]
✓ Transport in this area is very convenient.
The Cantonese 交通 can mean 'traffic', 'transport' or even 'communications' in English. 'Traffic' is the movement of vehicles on the roads, or the number of them. 'Transport', in this sentence, means the buses/trams/trains etc which are available.

transport

x There are many transports in Hong Kong. [176]
✓ There are many types of transport in Hong Kong.
'Transport' is the general concept of moving people or goods - it is uncountable. What can be counted are 'types/modes/kinds' of transport, e.g. buses, ferries, trains, trucks etc.

try

x I always try clothes before I buy them. [229]
✓ I always try clothes on before I buy them.
To see if clothes fit is to 'try them on'.
x We had lunch at 12.00 pm. [326]
✓ We had lunch at 12 noon.

twelve o'clock

'A.m.' means 'before noon' and 'p.m.' means 'after noon', so 12.00 cannot be 'a.m.' or 'p.m.'. It has to be 12.00 noon or 12.00 midnight.

updated

x She always wears very updated fashions. [74]
✓ She always wears very up-to-date fashions.
'Up-to-date' means 'modern' (e.g. for fashions or technology) or 'up to the present time' (e.g. for accounts or diaries). However, 'updated' means 'brought up to date' - i.e. for something that wasn't up-to-date:
✓ That old tourist brochure is old and needs to be updated.
See also MODERNISED.

USA

x The Szetos are going to USA next month. [189]
✓ The Szetos are going to the USA next month.
Names of countries don't usually take 'the', except for ones which are plural (the Philippines) and those which have 'State/Union/Republic/Kingdom' in the title (the United Kingdom). The United States of America fits both these categories.

use

x I use three hours to study every evening. [348]
✓ I spend three hours studying every evening.
Cantonese may use 用 but the English is 'spend' with the -ing form of the verb.

very

x I very enjoyed the barbecue. [330]
✓ I enjoyed the barbecue very much.
✓ The barbecue was very enjoyable.
Although 好 can come before a verb in Cantonese (e.g. 我好中意), 'very' only comes before an adjective or adverb in English. A verb uses 'very much' to give it emphasis, usually after it.

or: I very much enjoyed the bkg.

vocabulary

x This year I have learnt many vocabularias. [177]
✓ This year I have learnt many new words.
'Vocabulary' is the range of words one knows, and so, in this sense, is uncountable. Students of a foreign language learn many 'new words' and so increase their vocabulary:
✓ My teacher said my vocabulary was too limited, so I have increased it a lot.

wait

x I was waiting the bus to come. [263]
✓ I was waiting for the bus to come.
One waits 'for' something or someone:
✓ She waited for me at the Star Ferry.

waste

1 x I waste two hours going to work every day. [47]
✓ I spend two hours going to work every day.
In English, time is only 'wasted' if it serves no purpose at all:
✓ I wasted an hour going to the library only to find it was closed.
2 x A taxi wastes you a lot of money. [365]
✓ A taxi costs you a lot of money.
Again, the money is not 'wasted' because it has helped you get to your destination quickly.
✓ She wastes a lot of money on sweets that harm her teeth and make her fat.

watch

1 x I watched my watch and saw I was late. [79]
✓ I looked at my watch and saw I was late.
To 'watch' is to look at something/ someone for a period of time (睇住) while 'look at' is the verb for giving a brief glance (睇).
2 x My young sister loves watching comics. [79]
✓ My young sister loves reading comics.
The Cantonese 睇 covers different

'reads' books/comics/newspapers,
'sees' a film/movie and 'watches'
television.

watcher

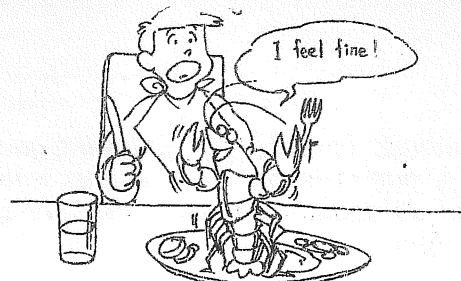
- x The new TV channel hopes to attract many watchers. [366]
- ✓ The new TV channel hopes to attract many viewers.
People who watch TV are 'viewers'.
People can, however, be bird-watchers, China-watchers, etc, when they are studying something.

wear

- 1 x At 7 a.m. I get up and wear my uniform. [80]
- ✓ At 7 a.m. I get up and put on my uniform.
The Cantonese 着 can mean both 'put on' and 'wear'. In English a student 'puts on' her uniform in the morning and 'wears' it for most of the day.
- 2 x Before I bought the jeans I asked if I could wear them. [80]
- ✓ Before I bought the jeans I asked if I could try them on.
To wear something for a few minutes to see if it fits is to 'try it on'.

welcome

- x Cantonese films are welcomed by Hong Kong people. [48]
- ✓ Cantonese films are popular with Hong Kong people.
In Cantonese, 歡迎 is used here but the English equivalent is 'popular'.
'Welcome' is usually used with people:
✓ They went to the airport to welcome their overseas friends to Hong Kong.



- ✓ The food was very good.
'Well' as an adjective means 'healthy'.
But it is also the adverb for 'good', a rather different meaning.

went

- 1 x Because of a traffic jam I went to school late. [81]
- ✓ Because of a traffic jam I arrived at school late.
The verb 'go/went' covers the whole process of leaving, travelling and arriving. In this case only the arriving was late.
- 2 x I went to school at the usual time but the bus was late. [81]
- ✓ I left for school at the usual time but the bus was late.
Here, only the leaving home was on time.

willing

- x Many people are willing to go abroad for holidays. [50]
- ✓ Many people want to go abroad for holidays.
To 'be willing' is not the same as to 'want'. It is used in situations where people agree to do something that is not, in itself, what they want to do, but which they are 'willing' to do for other reasons:
✓ Peter is willing to work on Sunday and we'll give him a day off next week.

82

wish

- x I wish you will get good results in the exams. [51]
- ✓ I hope you get good results in the exams.
In Cantonese 希望 is used for both 'hope' and 'wish'. In English 'hope' is used for things which have a real possibility of happening (often with a present or future tense or infinitive).
'Wish' is used (often with a past or subjunctive tense) for things that are unlikely or impossible:
✓ I wish I were the most intelligent student in Hong Kong.
The main exception is where 'wish' is used like the Cantonese 祝 and is followed by a noun or noun clause:
✓ I wish you a safe journey and a happy holiday.

world

- x This is a fine harbour in the world. [125]
- ✓ This is a fine harbour.
- ✓ This is one of the finest harbours in the world.
'In the world' should not be used unless the harbour is compared to others in the world. It couldn't be anywhere else but in the world! See also FAMOUS.

worth

- x It is worth to see Beijing. [271]
- ✓ It is worth seeing Beijing.
'Worth' is followed by the '-ing' form of the verb.
- ✓ Beijing is worth seeing.

worthy

- x It is very worthy to visit the Peak. [52]
- ✓ It is very worthwhile to visit the Peak.
'Worthwhile' means 'a good use of one's time', but 'worthy' means 'deserving':
✓ She's a worthy person to be manager.

wrong

- x I got on a wrong bus and missed the appointment. [190]
- ✓ I got on the wrong bus and missed the appointment.

83

year

- 1 x The Maks have a ten years old boy. [210]
- ✓ The Maks have a ten-year-old boy.
'Year' is not plural here because it is part of an adjective. Hyphens must be used because neither 'ten' nor 'year' nor 'old' describe the boy in themselves. They only describe the boy when joined together.
However, 'years' is plural following the verb 'to be' because it is then a noun:
✓ The Mak's son is ten years old. [126]
- x The Yeungs have a girl of seven years old.
- ✓ The Yeungs have a girl of seven.
A person's age can also be given without 'years' or 'old' in expressions like 'a man of 90', 'a woman of 30' etc.

your

- 1 x Thanks for your coming. [127]
- ✓ Thanks for coming.
This may be influenced by the Cantonese 多謝你黎 but 'your' is not used in English as the person is quite clear from 'thanks/thank you'.
- 2 x I haven't received your letter for a long time. [367]
- ✓ I haven't received a letter from you for a long time.
It's not a specific letter that's being referred to but rather the absence of a letter.

< END of Common Errors >

Proofreading: In each of the following questions, there is one or no mistake. For each question, you may underline one word and write another word above it to replace it; or put a ^ between two words and write down an additional word above the ^; or cross out one redundant word. If there is no mistake, put a ✓ on the far right.

1. Since that locker does not look safety, I store my valuables in my school bag during PE lessons.
2. In order to raise the amount of sales of the shop, the sales put up an eye-catching poster at the entrance.
3. It rains hard, so that we have to spend our afternoon playing Monopoly at home.
4. This 22-year-old boy has become the most succeed salesperson of that boutique.
5. My mother does not like very up-to-date clothes; my grandmother does not too.
6. Every year, quite a number of people in HK suicide due to pressure; I suggest depressed people seek help from social workers.
7. It is worth learning Photoshop since you can use this software to edit photos easily.
8. At 12:00 a.m., the servant will bring the lunchbox to his boss.
9. Though he likes the film very much, I can sure that he has not bought the DVD of the film, since the DVD is very expensive!
10. While I was sitting the ferry, I saw the rainbow!
11. A staff in that bookshop suggested I should buy that book written by Ba Jin.
12. I was so surprise that she did not go to the airport to welcome BoA!
13. It was so surprise that she did not go to the airport to welcome BoA!
14. Since Kent did not feel well, so he returned home early.
15. I will spend \$10,000 buying a car so I can travel around conveniently at weekends.
16. In this English lesson, she learnt 20 new vocabularies.
17. I think I should set off now, since my friend is waiting me downstairs.
18. Is this rude man the so-call Mr. Gentleman?